

Animal Kindom

Maharashtra

KARNATAKA

Andhra Pradesh

With the Mysore Zoo putting up animals for adoption by the public, conservation enters the mainstream and the zoo turns sustainable

● MYSORE



A ZOO OFFICIAL OUTSIDE AN ADOPTED GIRAFFE'S ENCLOSURE

| By Stephen David |

Vijaya is 18 and a powerful picture when she lies down in the grass under a gigantic rain tree—her personal space. In fact, nobody dares go near Vijaya, a Bengal Tiger, but Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa's family was so awestruck that it adopted her for a whole year. Vijaya is now one of the 600-odd inhabitants of the Mysore Zoo to be adopted by people—part of its seven-year effort to raise conservation consciousness and money. One of the few Indian zoos to survive without substantial state or Central government funding, it spends close to Rs 1.5 crore a year on food, veterinary care and maintenance charges.

"For feeding 130 species, 130 different types of diet are prepared in the kitchen everyday," says Executive Director Vijay Ranjan Singh. The tiger alone will need at least 12 to 14 kg meat daily. Yoga guru B.K.S. Iyengar gave himself a wild birthday gift as he turned 90 last December by adopting a tiger, paying Rs 90,000 as the adoption fee for seven-year-old male Brahma, becoming one of the 26 lifetime adopters. Even corporates like Karnataka Silk Industries Corporation and the Bank of

Maharashtra spend more than Rs 60,000 each to maintain a giraffe and a chimp. The scheme, first introduced in 2001-02 by Singh's predecessor, could raise only Rs 38,703 for seven animals but the zoo has become self-reliant now. Adoption costs vary between Rs 500 for a lovebird and Rs 30,000 for a leopard; from Rs 3,000 for a peacock to Rs 2,500 for a king cobra.

Established in 1892 by Chamarajendra Wodeyar, the king of Mysore, the zoo is home to over 1,000 animals of 130 species, ranging from an African black rhino and blue-gold macaws to crocodiles and Russell's vipers. With the scheme becoming a hit with people—a Bangalore gynaecologist paid a little more than Rs 65,000 to adopt a chimpanzee, crocodile and deer while a superintendent of police in Bagalkot adopted two king cobras for a year—keeping the animals fed properly and healthy is taken care of. Ticket sales, which last year were at an all time high of about Rs 4.5 crore, meet the zoo's basic expenses. With more and more families putting their money for animal welfare, adoption gets an entirely different meaning altogether. ■